

**AI and the future of education:
Disruptions, dilemmas and directions****Context**

DISRUPTIONS: Taking the pulse of AI in education

The increasing presence of AI in education has sparked a broad spectrum of viewpoints. Yet, robust evidence to support these wide-ranging perspectives remains elusive. Some view AI as a catalyst for system-wide disruption - reshaping pedagogies, curriculum, assessment, management and governance. This discourse assumes an inevitable and decisive break from tradition and a radical shift in the foundational structures of education, raising profound questions about its very purpose. Others question whether AI disruption is as impactful, universal or transformative as often claimed. They argue that the prevailing disruption rhetoric, though varying in intensity, tends to be overgeneralized, overhyped and misaligned with on-the-ground realities. Some have reportedly adopted measured and more cautionary approaches to AI integration.

These contrasting perspectives prompt critical inquiry: How does AI intersect with education in diverse social, cultural and economic contexts? Who benefits from its expansion, and who is left behind? Moving beyond sweeping assertions, an open and informed dialogue requires a reality check involving deep engagement with the multiple and often contradictory realities influencing AI's role in education and education's role in a world impacted by AI across the globe.

DILEMMAS: Reclaiming human agency in an AI era

As the influence of AI expands in various social domains and global contexts, education actors – teachers, students, policy-makers and researchers – face pressing ethical and pedagogical dilemmas. AI tools are often framed as solutions to learning gaps, offering personalization and automation. Yet, they also introduce new layers of inequity, digital surveillance and systemic biases, as well as raise concerns that overreliance on AI tools can reduce the essential relational and human aspects of teaching. Leveraging AI for efficiency gains, such as in administrative tasks or assessments can erode human accountability in decision-making. The rush to integrate AI in schools may also divert attention and financial resources from more pressing educational needs, leading to difficult choices on resource allocation and prioritization. Furthermore, as AI automates a growing array of human tasks in the world of work, education systems face mounting pressure to prepare students for futures where human agency is reclaimed amidst growing human-machine co-existence.

DIRECTIONS: Reimagining and recalibrating education futures we want

Reimagining education futures with AI requires recalibrating key directions across policy, pedagogy, infrastructure and governance to ensure AI fosters learning equity, embeds ethics by design and centres human agency. As AI systems grow more sophisticated, autonomous and extractive, shaping their trajectory is not just a necessity but a shared societal responsibility. Education, as a shared public endeavour, must actively direct AI towards serving the pedagogical, cultural and social needs of diverse communities. This calls for AI-capable education leaders, students and teachers who can not only engage with AI responsibly, but also actively co-create the norms, policies and research agendas that will govern its ethical design and use, both within education and beyond.

Digital Learning Week 2025: A platform for collective reimagining

Digital Learning Week 2025 offers a space for bold and necessary conversations about technology's intersections with education futures. The event weaves together a rich tapestry of diverse voices and viewpoints, serving as a compass for collective exploration of plausible, alternative futures. It invites governments, private providers, researchers, students and educators to engage in meaningful dialogue to challenge prevailing narratives, share evidence and shape the path forward.

As underscored in UNESCO's 2021 report [*Reimagining our futures together: A new social contract for education*](#), the world stands at a pivotal moment – one that demands a fundamental shift in how education is conceived and enacted. Digital Learning Week 2025 provides both an opportunity and responsibility to chart pathways towards equitable education futures in a world increasingly mediated by digital technologies.

Aims and objectives

Through an engaging programme of ministerial roundtables, multistakeholder dialogues, public lectures, workshops and live demonstrations, Digital Learning Week 2025 aims to:

- **Foster critical reflection and visionary thinking:** To explore the implications of AI for education, prompting stakeholders to look beyond today's challenges and collaboratively envision the future of education.
- **Encourage multistakeholder dialogue and capacity building:** To provide a unique platform for diverse stakeholders to engage with one and another, ensuring the development of inclusive, just and sustainable digital education practices for the future.
- **Co-create key resources and tools:** To launch UNESCO-led knowledge products and tools, including think pieces on AI and learning futures, quality standards for digital learning platforms, and global capacity-building materials for policy-makers and educators, inviting feedback and contributions in the spirit of co-creation.
- **Imagine futures through foresight approaches:** To explore foresight and anticipatory methodologies that enable education actors to define and navigate a range of potential AI futures, by analysing emerging trends, addressing challenges and uncovering opportunities for proactive engagement.

Participants

Ministers and policy-makers; heads and representatives of UN agencies and international organizations, development partners, private actors, civil society organizations, youth groups, administrators, researchers and education practitioners at all levels.

Venue and format

The event will take place in-person at UNESCO Headquarters in Paris, France. Plenary sessions will be livestreamed to a global audience with interpretation service in English and French. The Digital Learning Week 2025 event spans four engaging days:

- **DAY 1: Taking stock of AI in education**

Day 1 will begin with a review the implications of AI for education, scrutinizing emerging experience and evidence—or the lack thereof—on how it is influencing learning, teaching, curriculum, assessment, education management, governance, research and the teaching profession.

- **DAY 2: Choices, decisions and actions**

Day 2 will focus on how education leaders, policy-makers and teachers can proactively shape the development, integration and mediation of AI, as well as establish norms, policies, research agendas and practices that can guide the responsible design and use of AI.

- **DAY 3: Deep dive dialogues**

Day 3 will be dedicated to in-depth discussions, convening diverse perspectives and methodologies. Sessions will explore foresight and anticipatory approaches to envision alternative futures and foster critical dialogue on the evolving role of AI in education.

- **DAY 4: Open ideas labs**

Day 4 will feature practical workshops, thematic working groups and co-creation sessions with partners.

In addition, as a prominent global platform for the digital education community, the event will also host daily receptions, providing participants with opportunities for networking and exchange.

Exhibition

An exhibition showcasing the work of organizations and partners supporting Digital Learning Week will take place at UNESCO Headquarters in the Salle de Pas Perdus from 2 to 4 September.

Contact

For more information, please consult the [UNESCO website on Digital Learning Week](#).

For any inquiries, please contact dlw@unesco.org. See also more information on UNESCO's work on [digital learning and transformation](#) and on [AI and education](#).

Provisional programme overview

Day 1 2 September	Morning	Ministerial roundtable (Invitation-only)	
	Afternoon	Opening	AI and the future of education: Disruptions, dilemmas and directions
		Public lecture	AI in education: Disruptive force or overhyped promise?
		Multistakeholder Dialogue	Rewriting the rules? AI's influence on curriculum, pedagogy and assessment
	Networking reception		
Day 2 3 September	Morning	Public lecture	Redefining human-AI collaboration: What's at stake for education?
		Ministerial panel	Navigating AI dilemmas: Policy-making in education at a crossroads
		Parallel sessions	Practices and knowledge exchange
	Afternoon	Multistakeholder dialogue	Balancing AI's promises and pitfalls: Policy and practice
		Parallel sessions	Practices and knowledge exchange
	Networking reception		
Day 3 4 September	Morning	Fireside chat	AI for the common good: A shared responsibility
		Foresight workshops	Futures of AI technological change in education, curriculum and assessment, and quality foundational learning
		Parallel sessions	Practices and knowledge exchange
	Afternoon	Foresight workshops	Futures of AI and teachers, higher education, and education governance
		Parallel sessions	Practices and knowledge exchange
		Multistakeholder dialogue	Steering education transformation with technologies: Exploring plausible and alternative futures
	Networking reception		
Day 4 5 September	All day	Open ideas labs Workshops, thematic working groups and co-creation sessions with partners	